It was just a suggestion. Saeed knew what he was doing. I didn't know that a casual suggestion would make history. Back in Lahore, I heard the news before I actually saw that famous match against Sri Lanka. I read about it in the papers the morning after. That afternoon, I actually saw the damn innings.

It was the stuff of legend: a quick-fire 37-ball century for the ages. That too in 1996, a time when even 230 was considered a defendable total.

Later that night, I saw the innings again. I knew Shahid Afridi was here to stay.

But let's be honest. I didn't discover Afridi. He would have made it anyway. Although I knew that he had what we Lahoris call *pharak*, the spark. That's why I took him under my wing.

Afridi was a shy boy when he started. He wasn't the abrasive, tough guy you see today. He was like any average teenager, a bit awkward. It's not difficult to imagine why. Think about it. The Pakistan line-up he was exposed to at the beginning – Waqar Younis, Saleem Malik, Ramiz Raja, Ijaz Ahmed, Saeed Anwar … He probably had our posters in his room. And then, just like that, he was among us. It would have been a difficult transition for anyone.

I soon realized that he needed a confidence boost. So I took him on as a project. I started taking him with me to meet folks. I began polishing him, making him come along to dinners and events. I've always believed that if you're a confident person yourself, it starts showing in your line of work too. Shahid Afridi, the teenager, needed that affirmation.

I captained him for 10 years or so, on and off. We became very fond of each other, of course. But I do wonder if we made him perform what we had hired him for: a quick-fire leggie in the team. I know that he has regrets about how his skill sets were not utilized properly.

But here's the reality. In Pakistan cricket, we don't do the whole personal psyche thing. We don't think about what the other person is thinking. We are not proactive. Imran Khan was. But he was Imran Khan. There's never been – and there may never be – anyone like him.

Unfortunately, by the time Afridi dug his roots in the Pakistan side, a crisis of confidence had developed not only in the team but also in my captaincy, a role that was assigned to me sporadically. He should have had more confident people around him to shape and chisel and hone him. But he did not. He was unlucky that way. Also, he was so young. He got too much attention. There was too much happening, too soon, for him.

Some of us stood up for him. I remember having an argument with the selectors prior to the 1999 tour of India. I wanted him in the squad, the selectors did not. Eventually, I put my foot down – I knew he was a match winner – and said that I would rather resign from the post of captain if Afridi didn't make it to the Test squad. The selectors finally gave in. Afridi proved himself: in the first Test, he smashed 144. He badgered the hell out of India. He became a sensation all over again. I stood redeemed.

But had Afridi known about his own talent, he could have been so much more. He was constantly missing the confidence to settle down. He needed someone to tell him, 'Pathan, you have so much already. Now fix your technique and see the places you can go.' That's what was missing.

To become great, you need self-confidence. He had what it took for any World XI to have his name. I don't like comparing the eras, but the 1990s were very difficult for a player like Afridi. It was tough to open the way he did, to hit like he did. Every opponent team had three pacers who could top speeds of 150 km/hr. It wasn't a walk in the park to have the sort of strike rate he